I Didn't Know You Could Cook

By Rich Orloff

JEROME: *mid-20's, paraplegic, uses a wheelchair*
MARK: *near 30, his older brother*
SETTING: *The kitchen of a modest urban apartment.*

As the play begins, JEROME and MARK are at the kitchen table finishing dinner. JEROME has gone to some effort to make the meal setting look classy.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *When conservative older brother Mark visits his paraplegic brother Jerome's house for dinner, he is shocked by two pieces of information –*
ACTOR 2: *his little brother is a great cook, and he is gay.*
ACTOR 1: *When Mark demands Jerome choose between being disabled and being gay, the ensuing conversation reveals how much the brothers have kept hidden from each other over the years.*
ACTOR 2: *Will Jerome be able to convince his brother to accept him for who he is?*
TOGETHER: *I Didn't Know You Could Cook by Rich Orloff*

MARK: Anyway, so he pulls up to the stoplight, and he begins revving up his little Corvette engine, and I think, give me a break:

JEROME: Uh-huh.

MARK: I didn't get my Porsche to be macho or anything. I just like how it feels.

JEROME: Uh-huh.

MARK: But he keeps revving his engine, rhhm, rhhm, rhhmmmm, so, so right before the light changes, I roll down my window

JEROME: Yeah.

MARK: And I say, "I think you've done a wonderful job of compensating for a small penis."

JEROME: You didn't.

MARK: Light changed; I took off; left him in the dust.

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JEROME: Wow, it's so cool they gave you a Porsche as a bonus.

MARK: Hey, if you ever want to get into sales. . .

JEROME: I think I'll stick with teaching.

MARK: Well, if you ever want me to help. After all, what's a brother for?

JEROME: Thanks. Not that I could drive one, anyway.

MARK: I'm sure they could adjust it.

JEROME: I'll stick with my Ford. We've developed a very intimate and trusting relationship.

MARK: You know, in a just world, they'd give teachers cars as bonuses.

JEROME: That'll be the day.

MARK: [Finishing eating.] This was delicious, Jerome. Absolutely delicious.

JEROME: I'm glad you liked it.

MARK: I'm really impressed. I didn't know you could cook.

JEROME: Millions of people can cook, Mark. Maybe billions. Would you like some dessert? It's chocolate mousse pie. Made it from scratch.

MARK: Sorry. No room.

JEROME: You don't need room for chocolate mousse pie. It just fills the crevices around the food you've already eaten.

MARK: Besides, I, I probably should be heading back to the hotel.

JEROME: It's early.

MARK: I know, but I have another meeting first thing in the

JEROME: You know - you know how long it's been since we've spent any real time together?

MARK: Six months?

JEROME: Five years.

MARK: Well, we've talked the last hour, haven't we? [PAUSE} Hey, Mom sent me that article about you in the paper.

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JEROME: About the disabled schoolteacher all the third graders adore?

MARK: It was a good article.

JEROME: It was your generic "Let's admire the handicapped" piece. They just filled in the blanks with my name.

MARK: Nobody writes about me.

JEROME: Look, it was a fine article; I, I just don't like being written up because I can do what people assume I can't do. If they were honest, the piece would have been titled, "Local Crip Transcends Expectations."

MARK: Well, I liked the piece. And even if this isn't... correct, I'm really impressed by how well you've learned to manage on your own.

JEROME: And I'm impressed by how well you've learned to manage on your own, too, Mark.

MARK: All I mean is, well, I never thought you'd move out and live on your own. I mean, I knew you could. I knew you could do anything you put your mind to. I'm sorry if that bugs you, but it's true.

JEROME: I haven't done anything special.

MARK: I'm not sure I could have done what you've done.

JEROME: You just haven't been tested.

MARK: Still, to live alone when you're, well, you know-I think it's quite an accomplishment.

JEROME: Well, it's not like I'm completely alone.

MARK: Why? Is someone hiding in the bedroom or something?

JEROME: No, I mean friends. You know, friends.

MARK: I know, friends. The people you put in your Rolodex who aren't business connections.

JEROME: I also, um, well, I, there's, there's also one special friend.

MARK: No, really?

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JEROME: Really.

MARK: Who?

JEROME: Oh, just. . . just someone special.

MARK: What's her name?

JEROME: Louie.

MARK: Well, if there can be an actress named Glenn Close, I guess there can be a woman named Louie.

JEROME: Louie's a man.

MARK: Oh, so he's just a friend.

JEROME: We're more than friends.

MARK: He's a good friend.

JEROME: We're more than good friends. We're lovers. Mark, I'm gay.

MARK: You can't be gay.

JEROME: Why not?

MARK: Because our father isn't henpecked and our mother isn't castrating.

JEROME: I'm still gay.

MARK: Are you sure you're not just doing this to be trendy?

JEROME: Mark, I'm a homosexual.

MARK: Well, I'm stunned. I'm really stunned. I never even knew you were sexual.

JEROME: Of course, I'm sexual.

MARK: Well, I thought, since the accident. . .

JEROME: Only my legs went limp; I'm one of the lucky ones.

MARK: Well. . . what do you know.

JEROME: To be honest, after the accident, I wasn't sure what I'd be able to do. At the rehab center, they didn't deal with our sexuality at all. At all. Then about six months later, I - I was watching this Mel Gibson movie, and he

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started getting real sweaty, and inside I started getting real excited, and outside I got real excited, too.

MARK: You're just doing this to be different, aren't you?

JEROME: Stop it! Look, I, I. . . I know you have trouble accepting things sometimes.

MARK: Like what?

JEROME: Like after the accident, when you visited from college and you offered me a hundred bucks if I took five steps.

MARK: I thought you needed encouragement.

JEROME: My spinal cord had been severed, Mark.

MARK: I know.

JEROME: It was physically impossible.

MARK: Look, I just thought you needed a little push to get better.

JEROME: I was getting better.

MARK: Everyone always coddled you.

JEROME: Dad never coddled me.

MARK: Dad never knew either of us existed. [This stops the conversation for a moment.]

JEROME: You're right.

MARK: Look, about this, this deciding to be gay thing, I . . . well, I just can't say I approve.

JEROME: Well then, I guess I'll just have to stop. Do you want to pretend I never said it?

MARK: It's not healthy.

JEROME: Mark

MARK: So I'm giving you a choice.

JEROME: What?!

MARK: You can be gay or disabled, but not both.

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JEROME: But I am both!

MARK: Why can't you be satisfied just being disabled?

JEROME: I don't know. Maybe I'm just selfish.

MARK: Have you considered seeing a shrink about this?

JEROME: I've seen a shrink.

MARK: And what did he say?

JEROME: He said I should accept myself for who I am and stop worrying about whether or not I can please my older brother.

MARK: That sounds like something a shrink would say. Does the school know about this?

JEROME: I'm sure some people suspect, but no.

MARK: 'Cause I'm sure a lot of parents would get pretty upset.

JEROME: I know. Some of them are already nervous about me. I think they're afraid that with me as a role model, some of their kids will want to grow up to be disabled.

MARK: Maybe you think women won't be attracted to you because. . . you know.

JEROME: Mark, I've been with women. I wasn't attracted to them the way I am with men.

MARK: What do you mean, "been with?"

JEROME: I mean everything you think I could mean.

MARK: Were these women. . . you know?

JEROME: Disabled?

MARK: Yeah.

JEROME: Some were, and some weren't.

MARK: So then women find you attractive.

JEROME: Well, not an uncontrollable number. . .

MARK: And you've had sex with them.

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JEROME: Some of them.

MARK: Well, that proves it. You're attracted to women.

JEROME: No! I, uh, the women were, oh, I don't know. I guess, I guess they were an experiment. I mean, I thought I might be gay even before the accident; actually, I was pretty sure of it. Still, I kept thinking, "Maybe if I meet the right woman..."

MARK: Why can't you just be disabled?!

JEROME: Look, damn it, I'm disabled and I'm gay, and that's the way it is, whether you like it or not or I like it or not or anybody in the world likes it or not. I didn't ask to be either. I always figured I'd get married someday and I'd walk down the aisle, and surprise, I'm not going to do either. I know I should be proud that I'm gay, and accepting that I'm disabled, and I suppose I am, but damn it, I've sure had to give up a lot of fantasies, a whole truckload of fantasies.

MARK: Look, if you've decided to be gay, that's your decision.

JEROME: Oh, yes. That's what it was, a decision. One morning I woke up and thought, "I wonder what I'll do today. See a movie? Go shopping? Turn homo? That sounds interesting."

MARK: Look, I'm sorry, I know this must be hard for you, but I just can't approve.

JEROME: I'm not asking you to approve; I'm asking you to, to accept.

MARK: Well, I'm not sure I can.

JEROME: Why, because I can't be who you want me to be?

MARK: What?

JEROME: It's like when you offered me that money to walk again. I think about that a lot. Was that for me or for you?

MARK: What do you mean?

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JEROME: If I could walk again, then you wouldn't have to face the fact that I couldn't.

MARK: Look, Jerome, it's, you know, I'm sure you don't approve of everything I do

JEROME: I don't want your approval, Mark.

MARK: Then why did you tell me?!

JEROME: Because you're, you're my brotl1er.

MARK: I know, but

JEROME: Because you let me tag along with you when you went to get ice cream. Because you explained long division to me better than my teacher. Because you taught me how to play catch.

MARK: You threw like a girl.

JEROME: I don't think it was a sign.

MARK: You know, you could've given me a little hint along the way or something.

JEROME: Like what?

MARK: I don't know. You could've had copies of Playgirl lying around. . . It's just, it's a scary time.

JEROME: I'm careful. We're careful.

MARK: Still

JEROME: You sure you wouldn't like one piece of - [One of JEROME's legs starts to spasm. It's not significant, but it's noticeable, and it lasts ten to fifteen seconds.] Uhp, there goes Old Faithful.

MARK: I thought you were taking medication

JEROME: I stopped years ago. I'm used to them; they don't bother me.

MARK: [Overlapping a bit.] Do you ever get spasms at school?

JEROME: Oh, sure. Not often.

MARK: How did the kids react?

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JEROME: Oh, the first time, they were freaked out. Then I told them that whoever got the highest mark on the division quiz would get to ride me next time it happened. They got used to it after that.

MARK: You have a lot of guts, Jerome.

JEROME: I just do what I have to do, that's all.

MARK: You don't have any more surprises for me tonight, do you? You haven't joined a religious cult or anything. You're not a gay disabled Moonie, are you?

JEROME: And if I were?!

MARK: I don't know!

JEROME: Look, I, I . . . I know this must be hard on you. . .

MARK: Well, you know, it's like one moment you think the universe is one way; the next moment, it's another way.

JEROME: No, the universe is always the same. The only thing that changes is what you know about it.

MARK: This Louie guy, is he, you know. . .

JEROME: An Episcopalian?

MARK: No, is he, you know. . .

JEROME: Handicapped? Crippled? Physically challenged? Lame? Euphemism of the month?

MARK: I don't know why you're so angry.

JEROME: It's because I'm afraid that if I ever turn into one of those "nice" cripples, I'll end up on a Jerry Lewis telethon.

MARK: Hey. Look, you're going to do whatever you want anyway. You always did.

JEROME: I'm not your little brother anymore, Mark. There's nothing you have to protect me from.

MARK: From what I've read. You know, this is a real burden you're laying on me. A real burden. [JEROME just looks at MARK.] You're asking me for more

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than I can give. You've always done that. You want me to make everything okay.

JEROME: I don't

MARK: You wanted the bribe to work. You wanted me to be right. When you were laying in that bed, and everyone else was crying and going nuts, you looked at me, and maybe you don't remember, but God, you really wanted someone to believe you could walk. I didn't think you could either, but if you wanted me to think you could, I was willing to play that role.

JEROME: You didn't think .

MARK: Hell, no.

JEROME: I didn't know.

MARK: Does anyone else in the family know you're

JEROME: No, I thought I'd try it out on you first.

MARK: So how'd I do?

JEROME: You were -.. . [Starts to cry.] I. ..

MARK: Jerome. . .

JEROME: I'm sorry, I. . .

MARK: Hey, you don't have to

JEROME: I wanted to look so together tonight.

MARK: Hey

JEROME: I just wanted -

MARK: Calm down.

JEROME: I . . . I lied.

MARK: You're not gay?

JEROME: No, I mean, yes, I'm gay. I lied about... Yes, damn it, I, I want your approval, and I want your acceptance, and your love, and maybe I'm stupid, maybe I'm stupid for wanting so much from you. . . Consider it a disability.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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